



United Nations
Office on Drugs and Crime



KEY INDICATORS
OF TRAFFICKING IN PERSONS
FOR THE PURPOSE
OF ORGAN REMOVAL

TYPOLGY OF TIP FOR OR



OFFERING PAYMENTS OR OTHER BENEFITS

Offering payments or other benefits to vulnerable organ donors in exchange for their organs. TIP for OR is conducted through the abuse of a position of vulnerability and other means.

FORCED MARRIAGE TO OBTAIN AN ORGAN

Organ removal might also occur through forced marriage. Depending on a country's transplant system, it might be easier to pay for an arranged marriage and then force a spouse to donate an organ.



ORGAN STEALING

Removing an organ under the pretense of providing medical treatment with no knowledge or consent of the victim: use of deceit and deception.

RITUALISTIC PRACTICES

Victims are often killed, and the removed organs and body parts are not used for transplantation but for religious rituals, magic (e.g., witchcraft) and medicinal purposes.





RANSOM OR DEBT BONDAGE

Victims are forced to give up an organ in exchange for freedom of movement or to pay off accumulated debt (e.g. smuggling fees). Traffickers can use force, threat, and other means to force victims to cooperate.



USE OF VIOLENCE AND FORCE

Removing an organ without the victims' knowledge or consent, through use of force, threat, or intoxicating victims with substances.



ORGANIZED CRIME AND ORGAN LAUNDERING

TIP networks operating domestically or transnationally organize illicit transplants in private or public transplant facilities, mainly using vulnerable organ donors. Operations are sophisticated to enable 'organ laundering', a method which allows illegitimately obtained organs to enter the legitimate transplant systems. This is primarily done so that health insurance companies can reimburse recipients costs of organ transplantations.

UNDERSTANDING TIP FOR OR

THE ISSUE

Trafficking in persons for the purpose of organ removal (TIP for OR) is a form of trafficking whereby an individual is exploited for an organ. With annual organ transplants representing less than 10% of the global demand, TIP for OR is driven by the short supply of organs available for transplant to meet the growing need. This disparity between supply and demand has resulted in patients' attempts to obtain organs illegally, facilitated by traffickers, often from vulnerable or impoverished communities where transplantation systems are poorly regulated and corruption widespread.

WHERE TIP FOR OR OCCURS

TIP for OR has been reported in North Africa, the Middle East, South and Southeast Asia, Central America, and Europe. TIP for OR is increasingly facilitated by e-technology and internet (e.g., social media, online trading platforms, dark net) which enhance and proliferate the operations of criminal networks. While brokers and other accomplices may operate online to recruit and arrange illicit organ removals, this form of exploitation requires the physical presence of a donor, recipient, and medical doctors in one location (e.g. medical facility).

PEOPLE INVOLVED

TIP for OR involves a large variety of actors, including recruiters, brokers, organ donors (victims) and recipients, as well as facilitators, including medical professionals, medical facilities, and health insurance companies. Medical experts, whether aware or not, are needed to facilitate access to medical procedures and facilities (e.g. laboratories, screening, post-surgery treatment), and make the illicit organ transplants appear legitimate.

TOP THREE ORGANS SOUGHT



Kidneys



Liver



Cornea